



Social media and customer relationship management technologies: Influencing buyer-seller information exchanges

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ABSTRACT

Due to the increasing array of sales technology, salespeople must understand how each application assists them. This study examines how business-to-business salespeople use different forms of sales technology to meet their boundary-spanning roles. Our research draws from social exchange theory and task-technology fit theory to test a model that examines how salespeople use CRM and social media technologies differentially to support competitive information collection, product information communication, and buyer information sharing. Dyadic data from industrial buyers and sellers is used to analyze the technology-behavior relationships. Our study's results reveal social media use and CRM technology both positively influence buyer-seller information exchanges; however, each technology takes a distinct route to enable the information exchange between the buyer and the seller. The results also suggest that managers need to champion the use of both technology applications to their salesforce.

1. Introduction

Effective information exchange between buyers and sellers is crucial for salesperson success. Buyers serve as a major source of market intelligence for sellers. Further, the means of communication between buyers and sellers via information technology continues to rapidly progress. Technologies such as social media and customer relationship management (CRM) facilitate two-way information exchanges between buyers and sellers and provide an additional lever for value co-creation. Information technologies, such as these, support the collection and assimilation of information from internal and external environments (Lacoste, 2016; Ward & Zhou, 2006) and help build durable relationships with customers (Trainor, Andzulis, Rapp, & Agnihotri, 2014). In general, increasing information communication channels and information sources enables boundary-spanning employees to collect more information leading to improved individual and organization performance (Moncrief, Marshall, & Rudd, 2015; Teigland & Wasko, 2003).

The extant literature shares a reasonable consensus that social media and customer relationship management technologies are valuable enablers of the buyer-seller interface (Agnihotri, Dingus, Hu, & Krush, 2016; Guesalaga, 2016). Social media usage increases marketing

opportunities for salespeople (Andzulis, Panagopoulos, & Rapp, 2012; Guesalaga, 2016) through market-sensing (Trainor, 2012). It can also be a powerful tool to collect market intelligence (e.g., Pérez-González, Trigueros-Preciado, & Popa, 2017; Scuotto, Del Giudice, & Carayannis, 2017). In a similar vein, sales organizations use customer relationship management technology to attain sustainable competitive advantage (Phan & Vogel, 2010; Zahay & Griffin, 2004) by improving marketing strategies, facilitating communication with buyers, and providing better services and support (Wang, Hu, & Hu, 2013). Buyer-seller partnership success depends to a great extent on communication behaviors such as information sharing and participation (Mangus, Bock, Jones, & Folse, 2020; Monczka, Petersen, Handfield, & Ragatz, 1998).

Information sharing is a key relational behavior in industrial relationships (Itani, Goad, & Jaramillo, 2019; Mangus et al., 2020; Newell, Ellegaard, & Esbjerg, 2019) as it can reduce information asymmetry and uncertainty between organizations (Dyer & Chu, 2003; Pei & Yan, 2019). Information acquisition from buyers helps sellers gain information and leverage the buyer's information advantage (Li, Zheng, Sethi, & Guan, 2018). Today's marketplace increasingly expects the professional salesperson to function as a knowledge broker (Verbeke, Dietz, & Verwaal, 2011) who ensures information sharing occurs within the business relationship. Information sharing within business

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